Chapter Thirty-One

The Unwanted Throne

Between 1204 and 1225, the Latin Empire at Constantinople is challenged by three Greek empires, plus Bulgaria

As smoke rose from the sacked buildings of Constantinople, the Count of Flanders ascended his new throne as Emperor. There he sat, in Constantine's old place, with scepter in hand, dressed in silk and jewels, presiding over "great rejoicings," over "feastings and ceremonies," over the old empire of the Greeks: now, the empire of the Latins in the east.[1]

He did not rule all of Byzantium, though. In March, just before the final assault on the city, the Crusader leaders and the Venetian doge had agreed that conquered land (and any loot worth more than "five sous," perhaps equivalent to $100) would be divided up fairly between the Venetians and the Crusaders. After Baldwin's coronation, the division was made official in a signed treaty, the *Partitio Romaniae*. Baldwin I was given the entire Crusader share of Constantinople itself, which worked out to five-eighths of the city, plus Thrace, the northwest of Asia Minor, and a few outlying islands: the center of the empire. The Venetians took three-eighths of the city of Constantinople for their own, plus the scattering of islands between Venice and the Dardanelles: seafaring possessions, for a seafaring people.

And a third realm was created especially for the French Crusader Boniface, Marquis of Monferrat, who had been the other leading candidate to